returned a couple of days later, he came to meet me once again, with the admission formalities all completed. There was just one hitch, he told me nonchalantly, which was that I'd have to sit for an entrance examination. This was more than what I had bargained for, but I could not fault him for using his initiative. Now that the die had been cast, there was no option but to follow through. It was strange to go to the University, show the admit card and sit for the exam surrounded by young boys and girls in their twenties and thirties. Apparently, I qualified and was admitted to the PhD programme in the Department of Defence and Strategic Studies.

When I was promoted to the rank of Lt Gen, it also put me in the run to become an Army Commander, as I had adequate residual service on my side, being one of the youngest in the batch. However, my turn would come in due course, as and when the current Army Commanders superannuated, which was still more than a year away. I would have to do one more tenure before that. The tenure of a Corps Commander is only one year, so I would have to move out by December 2016. I did not have any particular preference, nor did anyone ask me for any choice. In the first week of December, I received orders to move to Delhi as the GOC Delhi Area. Delhi Area functions under the Western Command itself, so while I would be changing locations, my boss would remain the same, i.e. the Army Commander Western Command, which by then had been taken over by Lt Gen Surinder Singh (Mech Inf). Another development that took place in December was the appointment of Lt Gen Bipin Rawat, then the VCOAS, as the next Chief. This change suddenly catapulted me into the fray to become the next Chief, purely on the basis of seniority. However, the government had appointed Gen Rawat as the Chief, overlooking two of his seniors, so this was just speculation.

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